FRONT AXLE - 181FBI

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DIAGNOSIS AND TESTING

GEAR NOISE

Axle gear noise can be caused by insufficient lubricant, incorrect backlash, tooth contact, worn/damaged gears or the carrier housing not having the proper offset and squareness.

Gear noise usually happens at a specific speed range. The noise can also occur during a specific type of driving condition. These conditions are acceleration, deceleration, coast, or constant load.

When road testing, first warm-up the axle fluid by driving the vehicle at least 5 miles and then accelerate the vehicle to the speed range where the noise is the greatest. Shift out-of-gear and coast through the peak-noise range. If the noise stops or changes greatly:

- Check for insufficient lubricant.
- Incorrect ring gear backlash.
- Gear damage.

Differential side gears and pinions can be checked by turning the vehicle. They usually do not cause noise during straight-ahead driving when the gears are unloaded. The side gears are loaded during vehicle turns. A worn pinion mate shaft can also cause a snapping or a knocking noise.

BEARING NOISE

The axle shaft, differential and pinion bearings can all produce noise when worn or damaged. Bearing noise can be either a whining, or a growling sound.

Pinion bearings have a constant-pitch noise. This noise changes only with vehicle speed. Pinion bearing noise will be higher pitched because it rotates at a faster rate. Drive the vehicle and load the differential. If bearing noise occurs, the rear pinion bearing is the source of the noise. If the bearing noise is heard during a coast, the front pinion bearing is the source.

Differential bearings usually produce a low pitch noise. Differential bearing noise is similar to pinion bearing noise. The pitch of differential bearing noise is also constant and varies only with vehicle speed.

Axle shaft bearings produce noise and vibration when worn or damaged. The noise generally changes when the bearings are loaded. Road test the vehicle. Turn the vehicle sharply to the left and to the right. This will load the bearings and change the noise level. Where axle bearing damage is slight, the noise is usually not noticeable at speeds above 30 mph.

LOW SPEED KNOCK

Low speed knock is generally caused by a worn U-joint or by worn side-gear thrust washers. A worn pinion shaft bore will also cause low speed knock.